

ADHD: Patient Information Leaflet

A persistent pattern of inattention and/or hyperactivity-impulsivity that interferes with functioning, beginning in childhood and often continuing into adulthood.

What is Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD)?

ADHD is one of the most common neurodevelopmental disorders, affecting both children and adults, characterized by a persistent pattern of inattention and/or hyperactivity-impulsivity that is more frequent and severe than typically observed at a comparable developmental level. Symptoms must be present across multiple settings — home, school, or work — and cause genuine functional impairment, distinguishing ADHD from ordinary variation in activity level or attention span.

Common symptoms

- Difficulty sustaining attention on tasks or activities
- Careless mistakes, failing to finish tasks, or difficulty organizing
- Avoiding or disliking tasks requiring sustained mental effort
- Losing things needed for tasks, being easily distracted, and forgetfulness in daily activities
- Fidgeting, squirming, or leaving one's seat when expected to remain seated
- A subjective sense of restlessness (particularly in adults) or excessive running/climbing (in children)
- Talking excessively, blurting out answers, or interrupting others
- Difficulty waiting one's turn

What causes it

ADHD is one of the most heritable psychiatric conditions, with genetic factors accounting for an estimated 70–80% of risk. It reflects dysregulation of dopamine and

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prenatal exposure to alcohol or tobacco and premature birth or low birth weight. ADHD is not caused by poor parenting or excessive sugar or screen time, though these factors can influence how symptoms are expressed day to day.

Treatment options

Stimulant medication is first-line and highly effective for core symptoms in most patients. Behavioral interventions and parent training are especially important for younger children, and combination treatment (medication plus behavioral strategies) is often optimal. Academic and workplace accommodations complement medical treatment.

Self-help tips

- Maintain structured routines and consistent daily schedules
- Break tasks into smaller, manageable steps
- Use planners, reminders, and organizational tools consistently
- Engage in regular physical exercise, shown to support attention and executive function
- Prioritize adequate sleep
- Use consistent positive reinforcement for children rather than relying mainly on punishment

Prognosis

ADHD symptoms often persist into adulthood for the majority of people diagnosed in childhood, though hyperactivity tends to lessen over time while inattention and executive function difficulties frequently continue. With appropriate treatment, most people achieve significant functional improvement. Untreated ADHD is associated with academic underachievement, occupational difficulties, relationship problems, and higher rates of substance use and accidents.

When to seek urgent help

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Seek prompt evaluation for severe impulsivity leading to dangerous or risky behavior, significant co-occurring depression or anxiety with safety concerns, or medication side effects requiring urgent review, such as significant cardiovascular symptoms or severe mood changes.

This material is for patient and family education only and does not replace individualized medical advice. For a personal diagnosis or treatment plan, consult Dr. Kushal Kharel or a qualified mental health professional.

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